PERSONALISED ROADMAP · STAGE 4 · $5M–$10M

The Manufacturer's PROFIT ROADMAP

Leaders lead and sales runs. Now scale without losing the systems and culture that made the factory work.

7
AREAS

By **Bernard Powell**
Premier Business Academy · Hamilton, NZ

STAGE 4 DIAGNOSIS

Where You Are The Honest Truth You're doing $5M–$10M. Layered leadership. Multiple channels. Margins holding. You're past "does it work?" and into "how far can it go without breaking?" The risks change - scaling without losing the culture that got you here, institutional knowledge, director-level depth, succession.

W H AT THISFEELSLIKE

The operational grind is mostly behind you. Leaders handle day-to-day. You're in strategy mode - capital, hiring at the director level, brand, potential acquisitions. But new anxieties replace the old ones. One wrong senior hire can set you back 18 months. A cultural drift becomes expensive. The bigger you get, the more your time needs to be about decisions that compound over years, not days.

12 MONTHS FROM NOW

If nothing changes, you'll plateau. Not painfully - just invisibly. You'll keep growing revenue but lose the multiplier. The exit window narrows. The next tier of talent goes somewhere building something bigger.

Top 1% of NZ manufacturers ever reach this revenue band. Most who do never reach the next. The difference isn't revenue - it's governance, leadership depth, and strategic clarity.

> ***"At $5M, the business stops being about you. From here on, every decision is either building the institution or reinforcing the founder trap."***
>
> **— Bernard Powell**

What you'll read next Production - SOPs and quality systems. Sales & Pricing - cost-per-unit and quote discipline. Cash Flow - Friday rhythm and forecasting. People - delegation and retention. Systems - documented process ownership. Marketing - referrals and lead consistency. Your Role - shifting from worker to owner.

AREA 1 OF 7

Production One site runs well. The playbook needs to replicate.

Your main site runs like a Swiss watch. But everything you built is tuned to one location, one team, one culture. To grow to $10M, the operating model has to become a playbook someone else could execute - at a second site, a second shift, or inside an acquisition.

12–18 months lost Unrepeatable processes kill scaling speed. Without a documented operating model, opening a second site takes twice as long and costs 2× the capital.

The Fix:
1. Document the operating model as a "site opening manual" - org chart, KPIs, equipment, training, SOPs.
2. Appoint a COO or operations director whose only job is to make the model portable.
3. Pilot at a secondary location (or second shift) within 12 months. Test, fix, document what broke.

> ***"The day I stopped thinking of Premier as a factory and started thinking of it as a system that produces factories - that was the shift."***
>
> — Bernard Powell

Bernard's note The first SOP should be ugly. A phone video, a checklist, and one clear quality standard beat another month of explaining the job from scratch. Clean it up later - the real win is getting the process out of your head.

AREA 2 OF 7

Sales & Pricing Sales team closes. Next: pipeline discipline and coverage.

You have a sales team. Deals close without you. But without ruthless pipeline discipline - quotas, coverage ratios, forecast accuracy - revenue becomes lumpy. At this stage, a 10% forecast miss is $500K to $1M of swing. You can't manage the business on gut feel anymore.

3× pipeline rule At this revenue, you need 3× the next-quarter target in qualified pipeline. Miss that ratio and quarterly results become gambling.

The Fix:
1. Hire or promote a sales manager. Their only job is forecast accuracy, pipeline discipline, rep performance.
2. Implement a CRM with weekly pipeline review. Kill the "maybe" column.
3. Set quotas per rep. Tie comp to both new business and retention.

> ***"Gut feel got you to $5M. Pipeline discipline gets you to $10M. The ones who can't make that shift plateau."***
>
> — Bernard Powell

Common trap Owners often mistake a fast yes for a good quote. The goal is not to win every job. The goal is to win the right work at the right margin, with a method someone else can repeat.

AREA 3 OF 7

Cash Flow Positive and predictable. Now: capital allocation.

Cash is positive, predictable. Reserves exist. The question at this stage is EBITDA optimisation and capital allocation: reinvest, acquire, pay down debt, or distribute? Every dollar of retained earnings needs a job, and you need to know which dollar is working hardest.

EBITDA discipline Every point of EBITDA margin is worth ~4–7× in enterprise value. A 2-point improvement on $7M revenue = $560K–$980K of valuation lift. Discipline pays twice.

The Fix:
1. Hire or contract a CFO. Budget 1–2% of revenue. The ROI on discipline is enormous at this stage.
2. Write a capital allocation policy: what % goes to growth, debt paydown, reserves, dividends.
3. Benchmark your EBITDA margin against comparable NZ manufacturers. Know your gap and plan to close it.

> ***"At $5M+, the CFO hire is non-negotiable. The discipline they bring pays their salary 10× in better decisions."***
>
> — Bernard Powell

At this stage Cash flow discipline is less about finance jargon and more about facing reality weekly. A simple forecast reviewed every Friday beats a sophisticated spreadsheet you avoid opening.

AREA 4 OF 7

People Leaders are in place. Now: build the bench.

You have real leaders owning real P&Ls. But the next wave - the director-level hires - is where the growth unlock is. A great operations director, commercial director, or finance lead can each add $1M–$2M in annualised impact. The risk is mis-hiring. A bad senior hire costs 12–18 months of momentum and 2× their annual comp.

$200K–$400K per mis-hire A bad senior hire at this scale - salary + severance + lost opportunity - costs $200K–$400K. A great one is worth 10× that.

The Fix:
1. Identify the 3 director-level gaps that would most accelerate growth. Hire against them - slowly.
2. Use a structured interview process: scorecards, reference-heavy, practical exercises. No gut hires at this level.
3. Build a successor for yourself - even if exit is years away. That single decision moves your multiplier more than almost anything else.

> ***"The three senior hires I got right at Premier did more for the business than any five decisions I made before them combined."***
>
> **— Bernard Powell**

Bernard's note Most delegation fails because the standard was never clear enough to inspect. Give people the process, the expected result, and a review point. Then coach the gap instead of taking the job back.

AREA 5 OF 7

Systems Systems run without you. Now: make them institutional.

Systems run without you. But they're still tribal - institutional only because your current people remember how things work. For a real multiplier lift, the next step is externalising the knowledge: certifications, audits, standardised data, documented management practices. A buyer should be able to run it without your team's memory.

+1–2× multiplier ISO certification, clean financials, documented management processes typically add 1–2 turns to EBITDA multiple at exit.

The Fix:
1. Start an ISO 9001 (or industry-equivalent) certification path. 9–12 months. The process itself will surface weaknesses.
2. Audit your financial reporting: monthly close within 10 days, clean reconciliations, quarterly board-ready packs.
3. Document your management system - how decisions are made, how people are developed, how performance is handled. Not just production.

> ***"The ISO process was annoying in the moment. But it forced us to write down how the business actually runs. That documentation was worth seven figures at exit."***
>
> — Bernard Powell

Common trap If a process cannot survive your day off, it is not yet a system. Document the trigger, the steps, and what "done right" looks like. Then test whether someone else can run it without chasing you.

AREA 6 OF 7

Marketing Channels work. Now: build a brand that outlasts you.

You have multiple working channels. The next unlock is brand equity - the kind of recognition that gives you pricing power, inbound demand, and a moat. Becoming the recognised authority in your category is a 12–24 month play. It compounds for years.

10–20% pricing power Category-leading brands consistently command 10–20% price premiums over commodity peers in the same segment. That lands directly on EBITDA.

The Fix - 5 Conversations This Week:
1. Pick a specific category narrative - "New Zealand's [specific kind of] manufacturer" - and own it consistently.
2. Publish regularly: thought leadership, customer case studies, industry benchmarks. Weekly cadence minimum.
3. Invest in PR and industry awards. Position yourself as the authority competitors benchmark against.

> ***"The companies that became category leaders in NZ manufacturing weren't the ones with the biggest ad budgets. They were the ones with the clearest story, told consistently for years."***
>
> **— Bernard Powell**

At this stage Referrals work best when you ask right after a win, not when things go quiet. One simple referral question used every month is stronger than a grand marketing plan nobody owns.

AREA 7 OF 7

Your Role Strategic operator. Time is the scarcest resource.

You're operating strategically - capital, senior hires, M&A conversations, brand. But the urge to step back into operations is strong, especially when something feels off. Discipline around your time is the difference between building a $20M business and staying at $8M.

$1,000+/hr At this scale, your time is worth $1,000+/hr on strategy. Every hour in operations is $1,000+ left on the table.

The Fix:
1. Work a defined calendar: strategy, capital, board, senior 1:1s. Guard it ruthlessly.
2. Establish a formal advisory board or governance rhythm - quarterly minimum. External pressure sharpens your own thinking.
3. Spend at least 1 week per quarter outside the business - conferences, peer groups, even just travel. You grow the business by growing yourself.

> ***"At this stage, the founders who thrive treat themselves as their most valuable and scarcest asset. The ones who don't, burn out right as things start to compound."***
>
> **— Bernard Powell**

Bernard's note Your highest-value work is choosing priorities, removing blockers, and making better decisions earlier. Every recurring task you keep by habit steals time from the part only the owner can do.

HOWYOUGRADU AT E

Moving to $10M+ You don't need to be perfect. Just these foundations. Achievable within 90 days.

• Operating model documented as a replicable playbook • Sales team with quotas, CRM, 3× pipeline coverage • CFO hired (or contracted) - capital allocation policy written • 2+ director-level hires in the next 12 months • ISO or equivalent certification path in flight • Category narrative defined and being published consistently

The jump from $5M–$10M to $10M+ is the single biggest leap in this roadmap. Most manufacturers don't make it - not for lack of ambition, but for lack of the institutional foundations. Build them now while the momentum is on your side.

Quick check before you move on • One number you will review every week • One task someone else now owns • One process the team can run without asking you

YOUR90 - D AY PLAN

The 10 Actions That Move You to $10M+ You're not optimising a business. You're building an institution.

WEEK 1–2 WEEK 3–4

1. Commission a site-opening playbook
1. Map the 3 director-level gaps that - org, KPIs, equipment, training, SOPs. would most accelerate growth. Begin Owner: incoming or existing COO. structured hiring.
2. Scope the sales-ops upgrade - CRM,
2. Start the ISO / industry certification pipeline cadence, rep scorecards. kick-off - set a 9–12 month timeline.
3. Engage a CFO (full-time or fractional).
3. Define your category narrative - one Brief them on capital-allocation page. Brief marketing and leadership. priorities.

MONTH 2 MONTH 3

1. Appoint an advisory board - 3
1. Review the institutional foundations external members minimum. Set - playbook, sales system, finance, quarterly cadence. directors, cert, brand.
2. Run a first pass at an acquisition
2. Set the 12-month target. $10M is a screen - what could a $500K–$2M decision, not an outcome. acquisition add?

90 days from now You'll have a site-opening playbook, a real sales engine, a CFO, director-level hires in motion, and a brand strategy. That's the foundation for $10M+.

Priority order Visibility first. Ownership second. Growth third. If you try to grow before the numbers and handoffs are real, you usually just scale the stress.

WHY BERNARD / PBA

You've Read the Roadmap. Now Don't Do It Alone.

Reading a roadmap is easy. Actually changing a factory is not. The owners who break through rarely do it alone: they borrow someone else's 30 years of pattern recognition, their own honest mirror, and their refusal to slip back into the comfort of being busy.

Bernard Powell built Premier Group NZ from scratch into a 200 tonne-per-day manufacturer, #1 NZ Best Workplace and AME Global Lean recognised. He lived every stage of your journey before coaching a single person.

500+ owners coached · 200 tonnes/day factory · #1 NZ Best Workplace · AME Global Lean · 141 five-star reviews

What actually changes when you work with Bernard

1. You stop guessing your numbers. The first session maps true cost per unit and your biggest profit leak. Fixing under-pricing alone often pays for the engagement.

2. You build the leverage you have been missing: systems, SOPs and delegated ownership. The boring work most coaches skip is what turns a factory from a trap into a business.

3. You get someone who has made the mistakes. Bernard has seen the ways NZ manufacturers break and the patterns that get them past $5M+.

4. You do not get a generic playbook. Every session is grounded in your factory, your staff, your market and what you are dealing with this week.

Best fit: owners who want blunt feedback and fast implementation—not vague encouragement while keeping the same bottlenecks.

WHAT OWNERS SAY

Real NZ Owners. Real Results.

> ***"Bernard is all go. Full of insights and immediate action. We have been blown away by just how quickly PBA implements and starts bringing positive change." — Adrian Day · NZ Manufacturer***

> ***"We have had great help from Bernard at PBA shifting mindset and getting stuff done that would otherwise never have happened." — Patrick Whiteman · NZ Business Owner***

> ***"Joining Premier Business Academy was one of the best things we have done in years. We joined because we wanted to improve the life our business gives us." — Joshua Prestidge · NZ Business Owner***

> ***"Bernard is the real deal business coach. Genuine, inspiring and full of energy and ideas. I am seeing a real upward trend in my sales results." — Tim Farland · NZ Business Owner***

YOUR NEXT STEP

Stop guessing. Get a Growth Assessment Session. In 45 minutes, a top PBA advisor will help identify where your factory is, what is holding it back and the single most important thing to fix first.

Book Your Free Growth Assessment →

500+ NZ manufacturers coached · 141 five-star reviews · Free, no obligation